

More on materialism

Topics in Mind and Language: Conditionals

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1. Recap

- Materialism
- An argument for materialism: or-to-if seems valid
- An objection to materialism: 'If P, Q' is often *unassertable* when according to materialism it's true (and believed / known to be true!).
- Grice's response: *conversational implicature*
- An objection to Grice's response: 'If P, not Q' can be assertable when 'If Q, not P' isn't.

2. Conventional implicature

Another idea of Grice's: there are special linguistic conventions according to which certain used are used to signal certain things *in a way that does not affect truth conditions*.

'She is poor but happy'. The use of 'but' signals that there is some kind of contrast.

'Even Gödel could prove this'.

Why not instead say that 'P but Q' is *false* if there is no contrast, and that 'Even X could do it' is false if X is particularly good at doing it? One argument concerns embeddings. 'Every task that even John could do will get done' is much stronger than 'Every task that John could do despite being particularly bad at will get done'!

Conventional implicature 'escapes embeddings'.

Conventional implicature is not (easily) cancellable.

Conventional implicature is a similar sort of phenomenon to presupposition (as discussed earlier) — maybe the very same.

3. Jackson's proposal

'If P, Q' carries the conventional implicature that the speaker has a high level of credence in $P \supset Q$ that is *robust with respect to P*.

Gloss 1: x has a high credence in A that is robust with respect to B if and only if x has high credence in A, and x would continue to have high credence in A if x learnt that B (and nothing more).

Gloss 2: x has high credence A that is robust with respect to B if and only if x's credence in A, and the ratio of x's credence in A-and-B to x's credence in B, are both high.

- This ratio is sometimes called x's "conditional credence" in A given B.

- Note that $(P \supset Q)$ and P is logically equivalent to $(P \text{ and } Q)$. So on Gloss 2 the conventional implicature of 'If P, Q' is equivalent to the speaker having high conditional credence in Q given P.
- A case that pulls the two glosses apart: 'If Reagan is working for the CIA no-one will ever find out' (Lewis). Faced with these kinds of examples, Jackson later went for Gloss 2.

A surprising feature of Jackson's view: according to him, 'P or Q' *conversationally* implicates that the speaker has a high confidence in P or Q that is robust both with respect to P and with respect to Q. So the bar to asserting 'P or Q' is generally *higher* than the bar to asserting 'If not-P, Q'.

4. Confidence-theoretic arguments against materialism

- (1) I'm moderately confident that if they went out they went to the movies, but I am very confident that they didn't go out.
- (2) It's unlikely that Smith won big if he won
- (3) It's starting to look like Smith won big if he won

Not just an idiosyncrasy of sentences that contain both 'if' and an attitude verb:

- (4) If they went out they went to the movies.
— You're probably right / I'm pretty confident of that / There's a good chance that they did / That's fairly likely to be true / I'm moderately inclined to agree with what you just said...

A similar argument can be made using desire-like (vs. belief-like) attitudes:

- (5) I'm hoping I've won a blue car if I've won a car

5. The 'Ramsey Test'

If two people are arguing 'If A will C?' and are both in doubt as to A, they are adding A hypothetically to their stock of knowledge and arguing on that basis about C. . . . We can say they are fixing their degrees of belief in C given A. (Ramsey 1929: 143)

Conditional degree of belief (a.k.a. conditional credence): $Cr(C | A) = Cr(A \wedge C) / Cr(C)$ when $Cr(C) > 0$.

Natural interpretation: your credence in the proposition expressed by 'If A, C' should equal your conditional credence in C given A, where C is the proposition expressed by 'C' and A is the proposition expressed by 'A'.

Adam's Thesis: 'degrees of assertability'